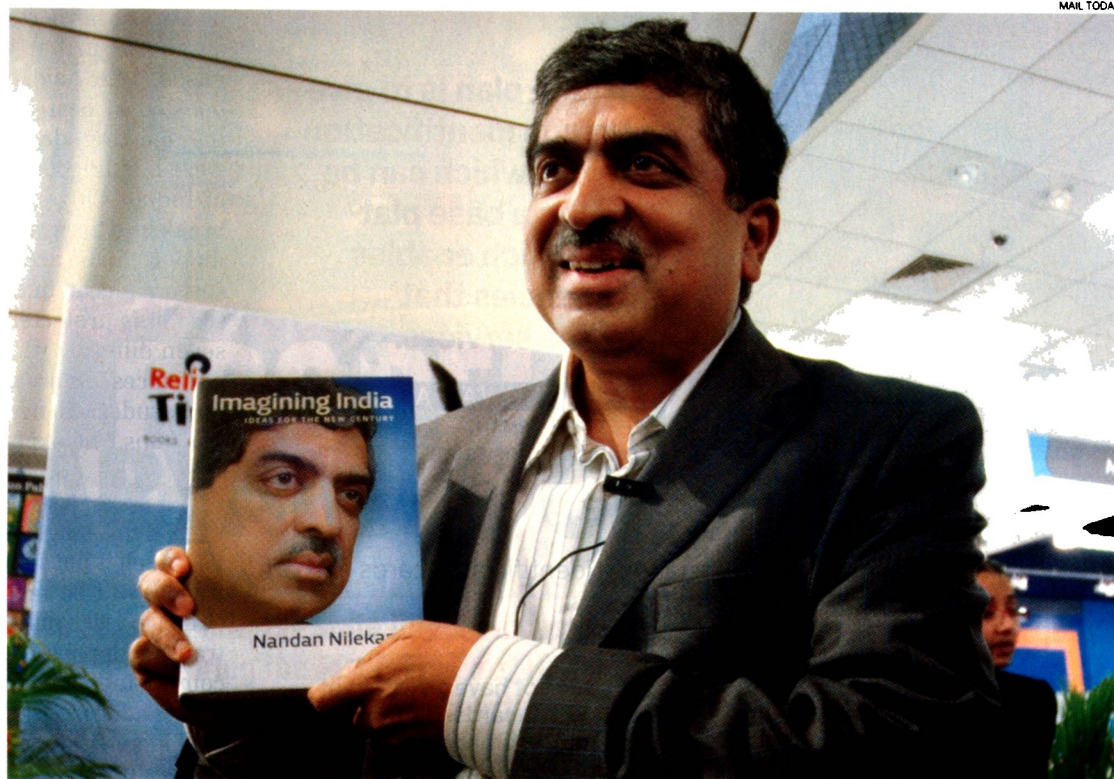


NILEKANI GETS TO WALK THE TALK AS HE HEADS THE UID AUTHORITY OF INDIA



Question of IDENTITY

As bureaucrats resent the imposition of an 'outsider', Nilekani may have a tough time putting his vision into practice, despite his cabinet rank and prime minister's backing

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

From the IT industry's poster boy to the UPA Government's poster boy is quite a leap but for Nandan Nilekani, it is also an opportunity not many get, a chance to implement his dreams. When the co-founder of Infosys put together his vision in a book, *Imagining India: The Idea of a Renewed Nation*, one of the themes was the need for a universal identity for each citizen towards "making citizen information and identity more verifiable" and to "make the relationship between the State and the citizen less traumatising".

Less than eight months after the book's release, he now has the power to implement that idea with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh offering

Nilekani the job of heading the Government's Unique Identification (UID) project. For the prime minister, it's a wise move. By appointing Nilekani as head of the UID Authority of India under the Planning Commission, he also put an end to the turf war which had been going on among various ministries and departments of the Government to hijack the Rs 10,000-crore project. It's precisely because of this that the earlier efforts to come up with a Multipurpose National Identity Card (MNIC) have been behind schedule.

Announced in 2002 by the NDA government, the turf war unfolded like a B-grade comedy. Initially with the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), as it is supposed to be the logical custodian of a citizenship identification project, later the Income Tax

Department staked its claim, saying that since they had an existing database of 75 million PAN card holders, they had a better chance to implement the project. The Election Commission said, by that criterion, they should do the project since they had a bigger database of voter I-cards. The Ministry of Information Technology, which had been tasked with the job of providing technological support to the project, tried to capture it as well.

To neutralise the turf war, and to empower Nilekani to deal with other ministries and departments as an equal, the prime minister has given him cabinet rank—equivalent to Planning Commission Deputy Chairman Montek Singh Ahluwalia. "This was the prime minister's message to his Government that they have to cooper-